

BERNERA NEWS

A Community Newsletter in association with **The Daily Ceilidh**

BERNERA MUSEUM AND IRON AGE HOUSE



Bernera Museum Opening Summer 2022

from now until mid September
Monday to Friday 12 noon to 4pm
Entrance £2 per adult, children under 12 free and all locals free.

Bosta Iron Age House Opening Summer 2022

from now until mid September
Monday to Friday 12 noon to 4pm
plus Saturdays 12 noon to 4pm during June, July and August
Entrance £4 per adult, £1 per children under 12.

TAPADH LEIBH

I just wanted to write a thank you to all the people of Bernera and Tir Mòr who have made me welcome over the past six years. As you read this I will have moved to the mainland. I had expected to end my days in Dun Innes, but sometimes circumstances intervene and everything changes.

I came to know many of you through "Soup and Sandwiches", "Allsorts", volunteering in the museum and attending functions.

Thank you all for your friendship and care, and to Mary MacDonald who took me under her wing and introduced me to many of you at the beginning. I'll miss you all, but intend to keep in touch,

Thelma.

MACIVER CLAN GATHERING

The Clan Maciver Society is celebrating its 30th Anniversary at an International Clan Gathering at Strathendry Castle on the **18th June**. We hope to have a piper to welcome the Clan by playing the "lost" Gathering tune, "Maciver's March", an ancient piobroch which was last played at a Clan Gathering 167 years ago. The Glasgow Herald of 19th Jan 1855 reported that New Years Day (old style) Celebrations were held at Asknish House, the seat of Duncan Maciver of that ilk, Chief of the Clan. During the unfurling of the old banner of Maciver, the piobroch "Maciver's March" and the "Gathering of the Clans" were struck up with thrilling effect for the assembled Clan. Some years ago the piobroch was rediscovered and transliterated into modern staff notation. As the Isle of Lewis is a stronghold of our Clan, we launched the Clan Society at the Caberfeidh Hotel all those years ago. Adults £30 p.p.

Children go FREE. Payments on PayPal to **claniversociety@gmail.com**.

Please advise us of your Name and Address by email to:
claniversociety@gmail.com



Iain Maciver
Kirkibost



AROHA ANIMAL ASSISTED THERAPY CENTRE



Aroha Animal Assisted Therapy Centre and Wildlife Sanctuary is a therapeutic space for people to enjoy time and activities with our animal companions. It can offer assistance to wellness through support packages to suit specific needs. Complementary therapies promote self care at the level of regaining a balance between body and mind. Aroha strives to deliver a confidential service respecting all service users. The main goal is to empower people whilst bonds are made in this incredible non talking therapy. Aroha is committed to promoting mental health awareness and well being.

Animal Assisted Therapy has proved to be a very beneficial and successful support for people of all ages and from all backgrounds. The animal can provide social and emotional support for a person as the animal is non-judgemental, non threatening and comforting. It promotes stress reduction, self-confidence and can re engage a person who is withdrawn, bringing them out of isolation. AAT has no barriers, animals make no distinctions, they can connect regardless of a persona, language, impairment, or challenges.

Aroha is a Māori word for compassion or kindness. Aroha Animal Assisted Therapy Centre and Wildlife Sanctuary is now a registered charity, with an incredible board of trustees. Our main aims are to make AAT accessible to any individual, group, or event. To empower people, promote mental health awareness and well-being.



The wildlife sanctuary is still in the process of being funded and when established we will be raising awareness of local wildlife needs and will have a dedicated team actively involved in rehabilitation and release of animals. All staff and trustees are committed to animals and believe they should be afforded the same consideration as humans.

Aroha is based in Stornoway Find us on Facebook at 'Aroha' or on Instagram @arohasanctuary.sty

CRUINN



In Autumn 2020, the Old Shop in Bayble once again opened its doors to the public, this time to promote the sale of second-hand clothes and other household items. It is estimated that despite the popular use of charity shops, globally 80% of discarded textiles are doomed for landfill or incineration. Only 20% are actually reused or recycled. When in landfill clothes can sit for over 200 years emitting the potent greenhouse gas, methane, as they decompose.

Local Sewing Craftsmanship

The Bayble Exchange project was established to highlight how the skill of local sewing craftsmanship can be used to increase the amount of clothing that actually gets reused and recirculated back into the economy.

Introducing the Cruinn Corner!

We've been busy behind the scenes setting up our new community corner which aims to promote the upcycling and repurposing of clothing and textiles! We are fully set up with sewing machines and sewing equipment and will have sewing/craft activities available for sewers of all levels - beginners too! We have a box of clothing material available for these projects, but you're more than welcome to bring along your own pre-loved clothing, to transform into brand new items. We will also be offering help/advice on clothing alterations!

The Cruinn Corner is based in the Stornoway Library - we are in the first room on your left as you go in. Thursday's from 1:30pm to 5pm - starting from Thursday 21st April. Hope to see you there!

www.cruinn.eco

POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - I LOVE MAY IN THE GARDEN



I love May in the garden, a fabulous month for seeing progress. Everything has started to grow, so if you didn't get the weeds out of the beds in Feb, March and April you have had it, because now they are putting down new roots and bringing up new shoots and soon they will be all over your flower and vegetable beds. My garden is festooned with Dandelions, as the first food for the Bumblebees. Over the years, following advice on how to encourage bees to the garden, I now leave the Dandelions to grow, and grow they do, alongside the spreading Bluebells. Now I have plenty of bees and other pollinators. I need these beautiful fluffy flyers to pollinate the fruit tree blossom in my polytunnels. Getting bees in them has been quite a problem over the years and though I pollinate the blossom using my handy little brush, it takes a long time and bees can do it so much better.

The white Saxifrage is coming out and will soon cover the rocks in my garden, alongside the pink London Pride and the Blue Bugle. Lots of colour, fabulous! I just love this time of year. All the trees now have half grown leaves on them, and the grass is overtaking the moss covering everything in a bright verdant green.

Today with muted sunshine and light showers, I am re-potting Brassica plants in coir pots to save on plastic, plus you can plant the whole thing without disturbing the roots. Also, I am sowing carrot seed in trays for the first time as I have found lately that carrot seed no longer germinates when I sow them directly into the ground. So here's hoping! Maybe this year I will get carrots again. My pea seeds are coming up and I hope to get some peas in the croft beds at some point. Courgettes are well up too. I am ever hopeful of summer and winter vegetables with some flavour.

I have been out putting in some carrot thinnings in the dug over Lazy bed, but also some garlic plants to hopefully ward off carrot fly. I have planted out just a few cabbages and was going to plant more, but now we have been forecasted heavy rain, so have had to find a way of hopefully sheltering what is already planted. Still, to cheer me up, my Guelder rose has flowered again this year and my Fig plant has three figs growing on it again.



Penny Spinks
Hacklete



BERNERA BAKES... THE BEST HEALTHY BERRY CRISP

Ingredients

6 Cups Mixed Berries
¼ Cup Pure Maple Syrup
3 tbsp Tapioca Flour
½ tsp Lemon Juice

Topping

1 Cup Rolled Oats
⅔ Cup Oat Flour
¼ Cup Coconut Sugar
1 tsp Cinnamon
Pinch Salt
6 tbsp Cubed Cold Butter



Instructions

1. Preheat oven to 350F/180C/Gas Mark 4. In a baking dish, add mixed berries and all filling ingredients. Mix until combined. Set aside.
2. In a medium bowl, add oat flour, rolled oats, coconut sugar, cinnamon, salt and stir until combined. Add in cubed butter and use a hand held pastry blender or your hands to combine ingredients until it looks like coarse crumbs.
3. Place crumble topping on berry mixture, bake at 350F/180C/Gas Mark 4 for 32-38 minutes until top is golden and the berries are bubbling.
4. Let cool at least 10 minutes before serving with your favorite ice cream or whipped cream!

Careen MacLennan
Kirkibost



BERNERA CATHOLIC MASS

Everyone is warmly invited to Catholic Mass, **Wednesday 15th June at 7pm**, in the small hall/dance studio at the Community Centre, with Fr William Maclean from Our Holy Redeemer Church, Stornoway. All welcome.

AN TAIGH AIR A' CHNOC



O choinn ghoirid bha mi a' coimhead air taighean mòra leis na gàrraidhean aca air an eadar-lìon.

Thug sin gu mo chuimhne taigh ann an ceann-a-deas Shasainn far an robh mi a' fuireach airson greis anns na trì-ficheadan.

Cheannaich Ameireaganach beartach an t-earras grunn bhliadhnaichean mus deach mi ann agus rinn e obraichean ùra gu leòr, gu h-àraidh leis an fhearann mu thimcheall. Bha ochdnar gàirnealairean aige ag obair làn-thìde.

Bha an togalach na sheasamh air cnoc agus bha achadh air cùlaibh an taighe le mòran dhitheanan eadar-dheataichte is dòire beithe àlainn cuideachd.

Anns a' ghàrradh air beulaibh an taighe bha seilisdheirean a' fàs, lusan a' chrom-chinn, iadh-shlat, ròsan is tòrr lusan eile. Agus chaidh faiche fad na slighe sìos chun an lochain aig bonn a' chnuic.

Dh' fhasadh an sealbhadair luchd-obrach gus drochaid chloiche sheann-fhasanta a thogail tarsainn an lochain agus an uair sin rathad - iarainn is treàna bheag a dhèanamh a deidheadh sìos bhon taigh tro thunail agus thàiris air an drochaid. Gu mi-fhortanach nuair a thàinig mise a dh' fhuireach ann, cha robh an trèana ann tuilleadh.

Air taobh thall an lochain bha dà achadh eile agus an uair sin chitheadh sibh am pàirt mu dheireadh: Coille fhiadhaich le craobhan is preasan de gach seòrsa, gun a bhi a' cunntadh an iomadh deanntag is dris agus an lòn bog.

B' e seo an t-àite a chòrd gu mòr rium oir bha a' choille dìomhair is aonranach agus na dachaigh do tòrr eòin is beathaichean.

A bharrachd air na h-eòin àbhaisteach, bhithinn uaireannan a' faicinn eòin eile mar lasraichean - coille, cailleachan - oidhche, corra - ghriathach is lachan.

Chunnaic mi rabaidean, feòragan, gràineagan is losgannan gu leòir ach nam measg bha aon bheathach sònraichte: sionnach.

Gach mìos air làn - ghealach, thigeadh e suas gu oir an lochain agus thoisicheadh e rì donnalaich. Abair dealbh iongantach! Ged a bha an sionnach ruadh, bha am bian aige a' dèarsadh mar àirgead ann an solas na gealaich.

Sa gheamradh, nuair a bhitheadh an t-acras air, bha e gu tric a' feitheamh aig uinneag a' chidsin, beò an dòchas mìr bìdhe fhaighinn.

Ach aon latha thachair rudeigin uabhasach. Bha sinn a-staigh nuair a chuala sinn, gu h-obann, ùpraid mhòr.

B' e buidheann shealgairean a bh' ann le coin-seilge, a' marcachd tro na h-achaidhean is na gàrraidhean gun chead sam bith, a' coimhead airson sionnach - ar sionnach!!!

Bha eagal mòr oirnn gu robh nì air choreigin a' dol a thachairt dha agus bha dragh oirnn fad an latha gun an d' fhuair sinn an deagh naidheachd nach do ghlac iad e. Abair faochadh!

Gu taingeil, tha sealg - shionnach toirmisgte an-diugh.



Linne NicLeòid
Dun Innes



ALL SORTS ACTIVITIES CLUB TRIP TO IONA

Having survived the last two years, the members of the All Sorts Activities Club decided that we would like to take a trip together off island for a bit of an adventure. Having rejected a shopping trip to Inverness it was suggested and agreed that we would go to the Isle of Iona where some of us had never been but always wanted to go and some had been once before but many years ago.



So at 5am on Wednesday 18th of May we left Bernera and headed for the ferry at Tarbert, the same vessel that later in the day hit the pier at Lochmaddy. After a hearty and welcome breakfast on board we decided to visit Dunvegan Castle on Skye. It was fascinating listening to some of the ladies discuss the family resemblance in some of the old portraits to some of their relatives here on Bernera.

After leaving Dunvegan we stopped for lunch at a converted barn deli and later in Fort William for coffee, arriving in Oban at our hotel for the next two nights we went out to a pizzeria for dinner before going for an early night.

Next morning, we were on the 10am ferry to Mull, which had a minor technical problem and so a half hour delay. From Craignure it was just over an hours drive through beautiful south Mull to Fionnphort for the 10 minute ferry crossing to Iona. We walked slowly from the pier to the Iona Abbey, letting the bus loads of American tourists race ahead of us. The walk was a bit tougher than we expected (some uphill parts not so easy for those who cannot walk far) but we all took our time and made it comfortably. Having paid to get into the Abbey we then spent a fair bit of time looking round this magnificent building and learning about the work of the Iona Community, a highlight was seeing the small shrine of St Columba. The simplicity and peace of the Abbey stood out for us all, as well as the magnificent location, which is quite awe inspiring. An easier walk back to the pier, mainly downhill, was broken by tea and scones at the Iona heritage centre.

The return trip to Craignure was uneventful and with the ferry back on schedule we arrived back in Oban at 6pm. We wanted dinner before going back to the hotel and having discussed this decided on going to a Chinese restaurant as one of our number had never been to one and wanted to give it a go now she is over 80. The meal was good, although a couple of the choices were not as expected, and we went back to the hotel for a drink before another early night.

Next morning we left the hotel at 9am and had a walk round Oban before heading for Inverness, stopping at a Red Squirrel viewing area at Inchree before a lunch stop at Spean Bridge.

Timing allowed an hour for shopping at a retail park in Inverness before heading for the ferry home. Unfortunately we did not take into account Friday afternoon traffic volumes on the A9 and it took us nearly an hour to get from Raigmore to the Kessock Bridge and so we were going to be late at Ullapool. However a bit of fast driving, going at speeds near the age of our oldest member, meant we were only half an hour late for check in, but as the ferry was late too we were fine. We all agreed that the staff on the Calmac ferries were great and having prebooked lift access on all routes we were looked after very well.

We had our adventure, a lot of country seen, with places visited for the first time or revisited to renew memories, as well as some other firsts for some of us. We all really enjoyed this trip and ideas for another being talked about already.

Catherine Macaulay, Margaret Macdonald, Joan Mackay and Colin Halliday were our intrepid group.

The All Sorts Activities Club meet on a Wednesday afternoon at 2pm in the hall, all are welcome to come along.



Colin Halliday
Kirkibost



CORNCRAKE CALLING



More often heard than seen, the corncrake's familiar crex crex call once rang out across meadows and crofts throughout the UK during the spring and summer months. However, believed mainly due to changes within agriculture, numbers dramatically declined during the last century. Since the 1990's, though, action by the RSPB, working with the government and conservation partners, as well as with crofters and farmers, lead to an increase in numbers, particularly in the more remote Scottish locations where they traditionally breed. Unfortunately, since 2014, when record numbers were recorded, the population appears to be in decline once more.

Though reasons for this are not entirely clear, it is thought that a number of factors have led to this decline, including the changes in land use and gaps in

funding. In order to address these recent declines, a project known as Corncrake Calling was set up by the RSPB. It is a four year funded project, supported by the National Lottery Heritage Fund, with three main aims:

Land management, encouraging more of the good agricultural practices which are known to work in providing suitable habitat.

Public engagement and education through a range of activities, helping to engage local communities, visitors to corncrake areas, and the wider Scottish public, about the corncrake story.

Advocacy, by working with farmers and crofters, as well as the wider agricultural industry, conservation organisations, and government, to develop policies which support corncrake and the farming systems they live in.

Alongside the work being carried out, a Core Areas Corncrake Survey is carried out each year, which helps to monitor the population in areas known to hold important populations of corncrakes, including the Western Isles. The survey is a continuation of monitoring that has been carried out on an annual basis since 1993, helping to determine the corncrake population across the UK. The survey is carried out between 20th May and 10th July with night time visits to certain sites, identified in advance due to their potential for corncrake activity.

This year a corncrake survey will be carried out in Bernera to identify if there are any breeding pairs using our local area, and to help form a picture of corncrake activity across the islands. Volunteers will be spending time driving and walking around parts of Bernera during the hours of 12 midnight to 3am, listening and recording any corncrake activity. You can help by letting the volunteers know where you have heard corncrakes, either in previous years, or this year in particular. To do so, please email **berneracorncrake@gmail.com** or call, text or whatsapp **07958 549784**.

Please also remember that corncrakes are a schedule 1 species, afforded extra legal protections alongside those in place for all wild birds within the UK. You're breaking the law if you:

- intentionally kill, injure or take wild birds
- intentionally take, damage or destroy a wild bird's nest while it's being used or built
- intentionally take or destroy a wild bird's egg
- possess, control or transport live or dead wild birds, or parts of them, or their eggs
- sell wild birds or put them on display for sale
- use prohibited methods to kill or take wild birds

It is important to note, however, that there are exceptions to these, including the legal hunting of certain species at certain times (for example game birds), and pest control under licence.

In addition, for schedule 1 bird species, it is also an offence to do the following, either intentionally or by not taking enough care:

- disturb them while they're nesting, building a nest, in or near a nest that contains their young
- disturb their dependent young

You could get an unlimited fine and up to 6 months in prison for each offence if you're found guilty.

GREAT BERNERA COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT TRUST

We are currently in a situation where we have the potential to build new homes on Bernera. First however, we need to show that there is a real demand for more housing. It is therefore vital that anyone who is in need of housing, now or in the future, responds to this questionnaire. Please fill out and return this questionnaire to Joanna George, 26 Kirkibost, Great Bernera, HS2 9LX

Email: jo@greatbernera.org or call **07771534048** Joanna who can collect it from you.

Name:

Preferred Contact Method: (email, phone or address)

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The questions below will help us to find out demand for new housing and what type of housing is required. Your name and contact details will remain confidential and will not be shared with a third party. If we need to contact you in the future, we will use the details you have provided at the top of this questionnaire.

1) Are you.....? (circle as appropriate)

- A – a local person or family wishing to return to Bernera
- B – a new, young family with children who would like to live on Bernera
- C – a new individual or couple who would like to live on Bernera
- D – an individual, couple or family who needs to remain on Bernera because of a support network (for social and/or health reasons)
- E – looking to downsize and wish to remain on Bernera
- F – recently separated and therefore in need of accommodation
- G – homeless and in need of accommodation
- H – other (please explain below)

.....

2) Are you looking for (circle as appropriate)

- A - One-bedroom property
- A2 - One-bedroom property (disability adapted)
- B - Two-bedroom property
- B2 - Two-bedroom property (disability adapted)
- C - Three-bedroom property
- C2 - Three-bedroom property (disability adapted)
- D - Four-bedroom property
- E - affordable serviced plot for self-build
- F - other (please explain below)

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3) When would you be looking to move to a new property? (circle as appropriate)

- A – As soon as possible
- B – within 12 months
- C – within 12-36 months
- D – other (please explain below)

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4) What facilities do you consider to be important (i.e. space to grow vegetables, good views, study room in house, garage, large garden etc).

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5) Do you have any other comments or suggestions regarding a new housing development?

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Thank you for completing this questionnaire